the assessment center

Most assessment centers use similar exercises. Here's how to be prepared:

At the assessment center, you and your fellow candidates will spend a day or two being put through your paces. This strenuous process is designed so that an employer can also assess applicants' personality and social skills as well. The fewer vacancies and the more applicants there are, the more likely it is that you'll face an assessment center. They are standard practice at big corporations and larger Medium-sized companies. So you may well come across them one day, for example if the company is looking for future managers.

Although the assessors at the center will often be company employees, there are also external HR consultants and psychologists who do the work on behalf of firms. All these group-based selection processes tend to follow a similar structure. You should definitely familiarize yourself carefully with the various formats and run through them beforehand.

Whatever you're tasked to do, keep an eye on the time and make sure you're wearing a watch (preferably one that constantly shows the time without you having to press a button).

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Here are the typical tasks you might encounter:

Self-presentation

A typical assessment center will start with a round of introductions or an opportunity for candidates to say a bit about themselves. This is similar to the “Tell us about yourself” interview question on page 166, where you can find more on how to prepare for this particular situation. This isn’t about going through the most important bits in your CV but about making a short, snappy summary of your unique experiences and skills or highlights from your studies that are relevant to the job. Be sure to practice a short version (one minute) and a longer version (five minutes) in advance.

Mailbox

You’ll either be given some unopened letters, meeting requests, or notes in a mailbox put together specifically for this purpose or, in a similar way, will be shown some unopened emails and documents on a computer. The assessors want to see how you get a handle on a situation under time pressure, set priorities, delegate tasks, and keep appointments yourself. The most important thing to do is to get a detailed overview of all the emails or letters. The most important message might be right at the bottom. Sort out a calendar, use the one on your computer, or draw yourself one if need be – this will show you what meetings clash and what can be shifted where. Find out what exactly your job is in this imaginary position, how your department is organized, who reports to you, and which of your colleagues you can ask for help in an emergency. Now it’s time to prioritize. What’s very important and has to be done straight away? What’s important but not urgent? And what’s neither important nor urgent? Once that’s sorted, delegate tasks if you can, bear in mind who’s responsible for what, make decisions, and don’t lose sight of the bigger picture amid the chaos. At the end, the assessors will probably ask you about your strategy. Justify your approach and your priorities, and don’t get distracted by any follow-up questions designed to provoke a reaction. However, if you realize that you really did make a mistake, put your hands up and outline how you’d do things differently given another chance.

Role play

The role play element will also be familiar to you from your interview. They’re very often used for positions in which you’ll be in contact with customers a lot or where you’re expected to manage staff. Check out page 176 and learn how to prepare.

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TUM TIP

The Alumni & Career team at TUM also runs a workshop every semester for practicing for assessment centers.
www.community.tum.de/events

Group discussion

This is about discussing a certain scenario within your group. For example, you'll be given an argument or hypothesis that you have to talk about. Sometimes, you'll also be assigned a topic and various opinions that may not necessarily reflect your own views. Equally, you might be expected to discuss and devise a strategy for how the company can meet a certain target, such as marketing a new product. What's being tested here? Your willingness to compromise, your tenacity, and your persuasiveness as well as your self-confidence, your ability to hand out and receive criticism, and how well you get along with people. You'll often find yourself discussing topical issues, so it's a good idea to spend a few weeks beforehand following both the general and industry-specific news to stay informed about relevant issues. If you want to make a good impression during the discussions, be friendly and cooperative, take criticism of your suggestions on board, and make your own criticism constructive. Rather than dominating the debate, it's better to simply summarize the various arguments now and again, pick up on those put forward by the people before you and ask participants who haven't spoken up yet what they think.

Case study

The case study is about solving a real-life problem under time pressure, such as: "We're going to be launching a new product. How can we get it placed successfully on different markets?" "Earnings in Department X are poor and need to be improved. But how?" Tasks with this kind of practical relevance are designed to test things like your analytical skills, your entrepreneurial thinking, your ability to work in a team, or your creativity. You'll make a particularly good impression here if you keep calm, read through the task – several times if need be – and then give the problem some structure, allocate your time and get hold of the information you need. Finally, work out the solution accordingly and present it to your group.

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